Chapter 1 · Story

Maya arrives late. The room has already decided why.

An original story at the Common Ground repair café.



A fictional story. A real question about people.

What would you do?

Leo is assigning the opening shift. What is his most informative next move?

A Ask Maya about today and check her availability.

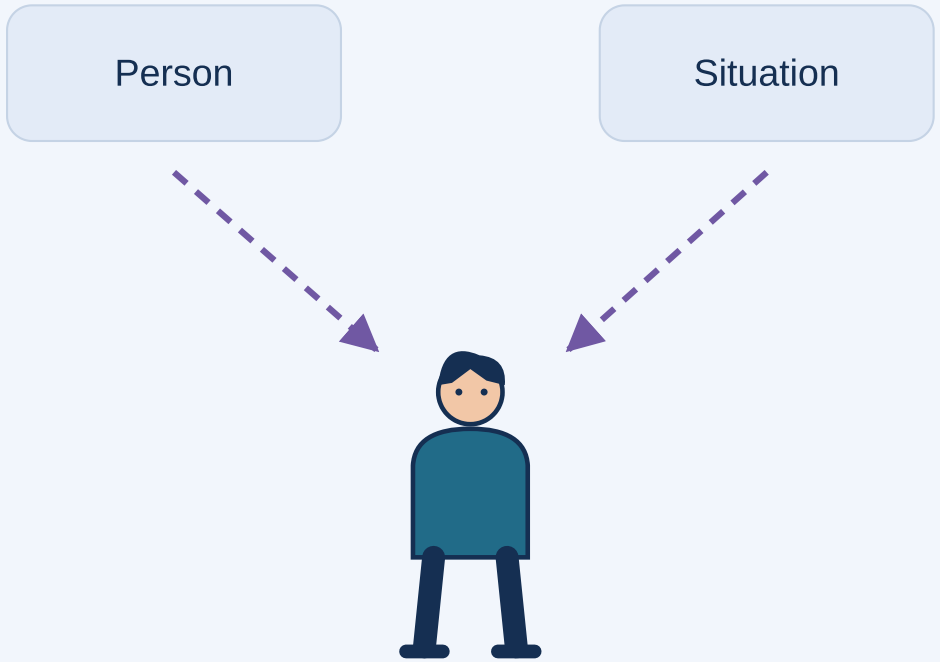
B Use today’s lateness as the main sign of reliability.

C Ignore today and assume she will arrive on time.

Suggested answer: A. Asking Maya about the delay lets Leo investigate the obstacle and plan the shift without ignoring the lateness.

Personal qualities meet circumstances.

- **Person**: tendencies, goals, beliefs, skills
- **Disposition**: a usual tendency over time
- **Situation**: demands, people, available choices
- **Interaction**: changing circumstances can change a response



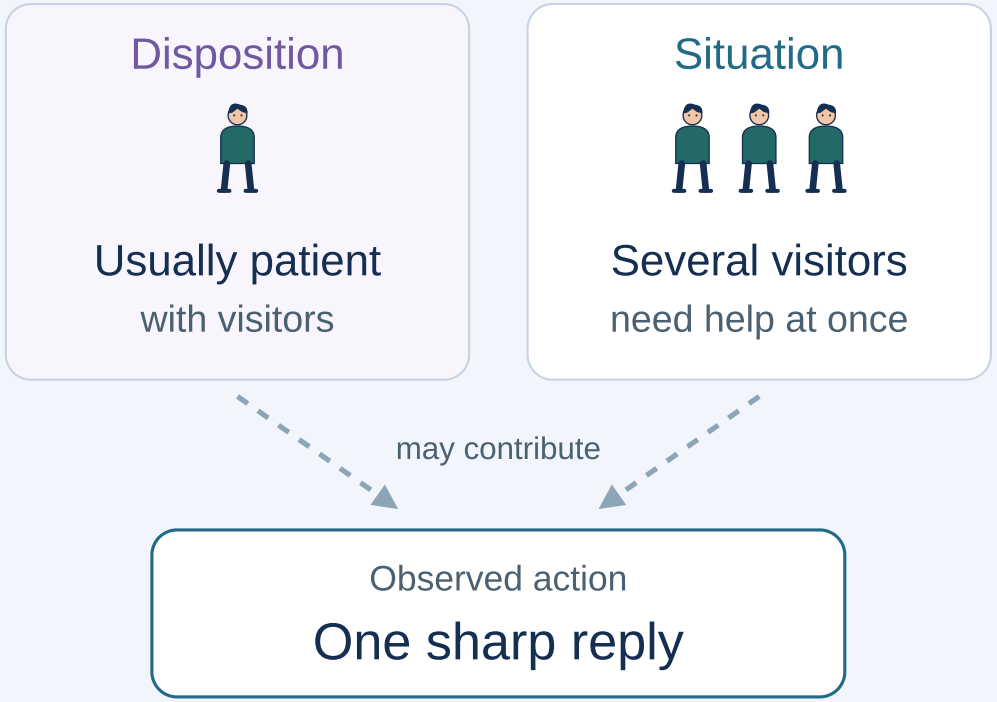
Behavior emerges in context.

A disposition is one personal quality; circumstances also contribute.

The same person, under pressure.

- **Disposition**: the volunteer is normally patient.
- **New demands**: several visitors ask for help at once.
- **Observed action**: the volunteer gives one sharp reply.
- **Check**: compare calmer and busier shifts.

A tendency meets a busy room



Compare calmer and busier shifts.

A hypothetical interaction of a disposition and a situation. Dashed paths indicate possible contributions.

Observation is not explanation.

- **Observation**: Maya arrived after the start.
- **Attribution**: Leo proposes that she does not care.
- **Different questions**: what happened, and what caused it?
- **Next step**: ask for information that could test the cause.

Two different questions

Observation



Maya arrived after the start.

A recorded action

Attribution



“She doesn’t care.”

A proposed cause

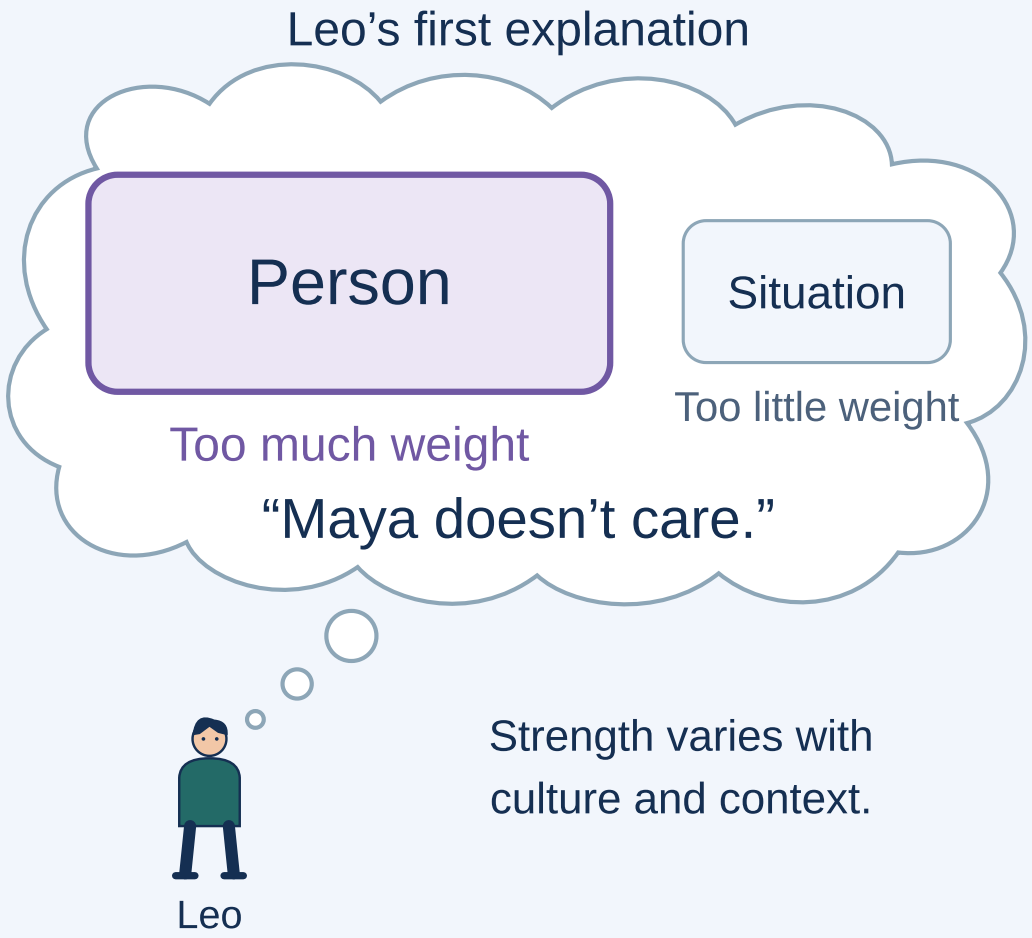
One statement records an action.
The other proposes a cause.

What evidence could test Leo’s cause?

Leo’s observation and his attribution answer different questions.

When the person gets too much weight.

- **Fundamental attribution error**: too much weight on personal qualities, too little on circumstances.
- **Leo’s first account**: “Maya doesn’t care.”
- **Missing context**: the broken lift and helping a neighbor.
- **Check**: compare plausible causes before judging commitment.

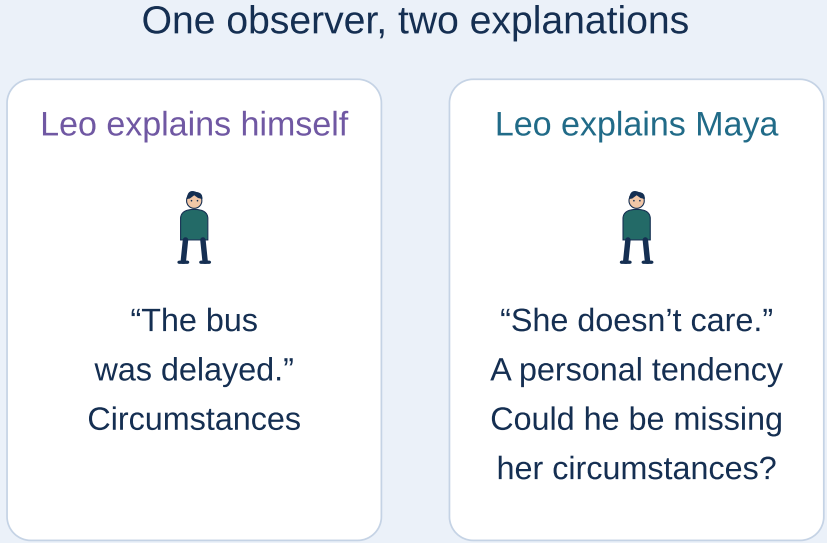


Strength varies with culture and context.

Leo gives personal qualities more weight than the circumstances.

One observer, two explanations.

An attribution is an explanation of what caused an action. Attribution research describes patterns across judgments. Those patterns do not settle the cause of one person’s action. Actor–observer differences compare how one observer explains their own actions and other people’s actions. In a hypothetical comparison, Leo might cite a bus delay for his own lateness but Maya’s priorities for hers. The pattern varies with the judgment and study design.



A possible actor–observer difference.
The pattern depends on judgment and setting.

Hypothetical explanations by the same observer.

Test the explanation.

- **Describe**: Maya arrived late; “doesn’t care” is a proposed cause.
- **Compare**: look across shifts, settings, and exceptions.
- **Check**: ask Maya and test plausible alternatives.
- **Revise**: change your confidence when the evidence changes.

Follow the evidence

Leo’s proposed cause

“She doesn’t care.”

1. **Describe the action**
   Maya arrived after the start.
   Keep the cause open.
2. **Compare occasions**
   Is lateness usual across shifts?
   Look for exceptions.
3. **Check alternatives**
   Could a travel barrier explain it?
   Ask Maya about the delay.
4. **Revise your confidence**
   Weigh the evidence for each cause.
   Allow your explanation to change.

Let evidence change your confidence.

Describe, compare, check, and revise. Apply the same steps to your own interpretations.

Try the idea somewhere new.

A volunteer misses shifts only when the bus service is suspended. What should you test?

A Whether personality alone predicts attendance.

B Whether another travel plan improves attendance.

C Whether the missed shifts can be deleted.

Suggested answer: B. Trying another travel plan tests the suspected barrier while keeping the attendance expectation clear.

Close your notes. Explain it.

> In Maya’s arrival story, what did Leo observe, and what cause did he infer?

> What evidence would strengthen an explanation based on a person’s usual tendencies, rather than one unusual situation?

1. Leo observed that Maya arrived after the meeting had started. He inferred that she did not care about the project. Her late arrival is the observation; not caring is his proposed cause.

2. An explanation based on a personal tendency becomes more credible when the behavior recurs across varied circumstances and plausible alternatives have been examined.



Maya, Sam and Leo at the repair café.

Carry one idea into your week.

Choose a mildly frustrating action by another person. Write what you observed, your initial explanation, two plausible alternatives, and one respectful question that could clarify what happened.

Revisit tomorrow and in a week.
Explain it without notes, then use a different example.



Take the question into a different setting.